Preface

This is the fifth edition of *Programming Ruby*, which many Ruby developers call "The Pickaxe Book." It covers Ruby up to and including Ruby 3.2.

Since the previous edition of this book, Ruby has continued to grow and evolve. New syntax has been added; old syntax has been refined. Major new features have been added such as pattern matching and type signatures. Tools that did not exist or were in their early stages of development then are now in constant use by Ruby developers around the world. The entire ecosystem is thriving.

The Pickaxe Book continues to be your guide to learning Ruby the language, understanding how the parts of Ruby work together, and how to use the most popular and important Ruby tools.

Why Ruby?

When Dave Thomas and Andy Hunt wrote the first edition, they explained the appeal of Ruby. Among other things, they wrote, "When we discovered Ruby, we realized that we'd found what we'd been looking for. More than any other language with which we have worked, Ruby *stays out of your way*. You can concentrate on solving the problem at hand, instead of struggling with compiler and language issues. That's how it can help you become a better programmer: by giving you the chance to spend your time creating solutions for your users, not for the compiler."

That belief is even stronger today. Thirty years after Ruby's first release on February 24, 1993, Ruby still enables developers to focus on their solutions—from the smallest utility script to the services of companies with billions of dollars in revenue. Ruby can support it all.

A Word About Ruby Versions

This edition of The Pickaxe Book documents Ruby up to and including Ruby 3.2. New Ruby point releases come out annually on December 25, with Ruby 3.2 released on December 25, 2022. The book's code is tested against Ruby 3.2.

For the most part, we do not note in the main text in what version of Ruby new features were introduced, but there is a brief list of the changes in Appendix 5, Ruby Changes, on page 573. We recommend referring to the Ruby Evolution page at https://rubyreferences.github.io/rubychanges/evolution.html by Victor Shepelev for a full listing of the changes implemented since Ruby 2.0.

Exactly what version of Ruby did we use to write this book? Let's ask Ruby: